

4. How have you planned your slides? You could pack more information into each slide and end up with fewer slides, or you could space out the information. You need to strike the balance, which depends on the elements you intend to put in.
5. And finally, how much time do *you* have, or how much time have you been allotted? Don't cram 15 slides into ten minutes.

Tip

We've talked about five steps to creating your slides. Here's an idea: spend quality time with your dog between the stages. Watch TV. Relax. From ideating to polishing is a long journey, and you need breaks not only to refresh yourself, but also to be able to change gears nicely.

Step 3

Flesh out the slides. You know this part: insert your charts, your text, and so forth. Do *not* bother with stuff like templates and prettiness at this point!

Step 4

It's then time to edit. Make no mistake: this is as important a stage as any of the others. Get into analytical mode, look at each slide individually and at the presentation as a whole, and decide what should go and what should be added. Ask a friend if in doubt; in fact, asking a friend even if not in doubt could help. It's something like being in the shoes of a member of your audience: how would *you* respond when you're presented a slide like the one you're looking at? You'd know, because you've attended presentations.

Look specifically for confusing, contradictory, and distracting elements. Try your best to keep the word count as low as possible, because you'll be speaking anyway—and the more words there are on the screen, the more difficult it'll be to absorb information. Never forget: your goal is to communicate information. Sentences can often be clipped to their bare-bones phrases; you'll be speaking the sentences anyway.